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javelin for India, one of them was always going to be Neeraj. For the second spot, Kishore was selected on the basis of his performance at the Inter State Championships in Bhubaneswar earlier in the year — a competition in which Manu had only finished fourth.

"The only way Manu could have gone to the Asian Games was if either Neeraj or Jena withdrew from the competition. When that didn't happen, he was of course very disappointed," recalls coach Kashinath Naik.

Manu soon got over it. "After this, my goal changed. I want to make sure that I get a chance in the Paris Olympics. That's the target for me now," he says.

Unlike in the Asian Games, India can send three participants to Paris. Throwers can qualify either by meeting the minimum standard — 85.50m — or by ranking among the top 32 throwers in the world at the end of the qualification cycle.

Two Indians have directly qualified for the Paris Games already — Neeraj Chopra did so with his first throw at the World Championships while Kishore followed suit at the Asian Games with his silver medal-winning effort. Ostensibly that leaves just one

qualification slot open for an Indian athlete.

The qualification of three javelin throwers for the Olympics would be a landmark moment in Indian athletics. And as we head into the Olympic season, it seems all but certain that this will be the case. "At this stage I think we will see India fill all three possible slots in the javelin throw," says Adille Sumariwalla, the president of the Athletics Federation of India.

India has a history of filling up all available qualification slots at the Olympics. Sumariwalla says, "We have had multiple instances where we qualified with all available athletes. Even for Paris, we secured three slots in the men's race walk event. But racewalk isn't an event where we have achieved a lot of success at the World level. On the other hand, India is one of the strongest nations in men's javelin throw."

Even though Manu is currently ranked among the top 32 athletes in the world, there's no guarantee that he will accompany Neeraj and Kishore to Paris in little over half-a-year. "*Is baar Diwali lagega* (It will almost be like Diwali this time). There is a lot of competition and everyone will be working really hard," he says.

On the face of it, Manu can be considered the favourite to seal the Olympic quota. He has after all the third best throw by an Indian this season. Before Kishore's impressive breakout in 2023, it was Manu who was considered the next big thing in Indian javelin, having delivered the

second-best throw after Neeraj.

That Manu is not able to seal the third spot with ease is testament to the surge in Indian talent in the sport. At the Inter State Championships in Bhubaneswar — the qualification event for the Asian Games — Manu finished fourth, behind eventual champion Rohit Yadav, a 22-year-old who threw 83.28m. Rohit finished ahead of Kishore as well, but the latter only went when Rohit picked up an elbow injury that required surgery.

Yadav is still rehabilitating from his surgery at Thiruvananthapuram.

However, he admits that his recovery is taking longer than expected. While he plans on returning to competition in 2024, he's uncertain just how quickly he will be able to bounce back. Perhaps the biggest surprise in the Olympic qualification race is likely to come from Shivpal Singh, who was the undisputed No. 2 behind Neeraj Chopra in the Indian pecking order prior to the emergence of Manu, Rohit and Jena in the last couple of years. The 28-year-old had a personal best of 86.23m that's still the third best ever by an Indian.

But Shivpal started this season under the cloud of a four-year doping ban, uncertain whether he was ever going to be able to compete at any level. In the end, he was cleared of any wrongdoing and won gold at the National Games, beating Manu in the process.

After a disappointing Olympic campaign in Tokyo — where he finished 12th in his group during qualifying — all hopes of a comeback

Star in the making: Even though Manu is currently ranked among the top 32 athletes in the world, there's no guarantee that he will accompany Neeraj and Kishore to Paris in little over half a year. K. MURALIKUMAR